

University of Central Florida
Department of Economics

QMB 6304
Data Visualization

Project - Stage 1

1. Provide references to the dataset(s) you have selected, including a brief description of the data available in each dataset.

From Harvard Dataverse, I retrieved three datasets relating to election results for the Presidency, the Senate, and the House of Representatives from 1976 to 2022. The most relevant information in these datasets are the columns of

- **year:** The year of the election
- **state:** The state of interest (e.g., Florida)
- **office:** The political office for which a candidate is running
- **candidate:** The individual running for office
- **party/party_detailed/party_simplified:** The party with which the candidate associates him/herself with
- **candidatevotes:** The total number of votes an individual obtained
- **totalvotes:** The total number of votes collected within the state
- **district:** The geographic area electing the candidates
- **write_in:** A boolean category indicating whether an individual was a write-in candidate or not

Additionally, through FiveThirtyEight, I observed a folder with data on political elasticity scores. This folder consisted of two csv files, "elasticity-by-district" and "elasticity-by-state." Within these datasets, the only columns indicate either the district or the state (depending

on the file) and the corresponding elasticity score. Updated in 2018, these scores are an estimation of how the likelihood of an individual voting Democratic or Republican for Congress would change due to changes in their political environment.

2. Describe the questions or key messages you plan to explore. Explain why these questions/messages are interesting and how the selected dataset(s) can help you address or highlight them.

I certainly want to keep exploring datasets, but I have many ideas for the types of messages I can address. Overall, I would like to show how political leanings have changed over the years across the United States. What with the 2024 election coming up, this seems like a relevant topic. The variation in political preferences over states and districts across time can easily be seen with the election results datasets. The elasticity estimations provide a reference of comparison for how various states/districts may change.

I hope to collect more data regarding demographic information (age, ethnicity, sex, income, etc.) that would permit me to highlight specific changes among those demographics. Additionally, I think it would be useful to find data on policies/events that have (or have had) national impacts and note their influence on voting patterns.

In summary, some of the questions I plan to address are:

- a) How have political leanings shifted over time in the United States?
- b) How do demographic characteristics correlate with these shifts in political preferences?
- c) How have changes in economic factors (unemployment rates, tax rates, etc.) and/or perspectives on social issues affected political leanings?
- d) How are swing states specifically influenced by political changes?